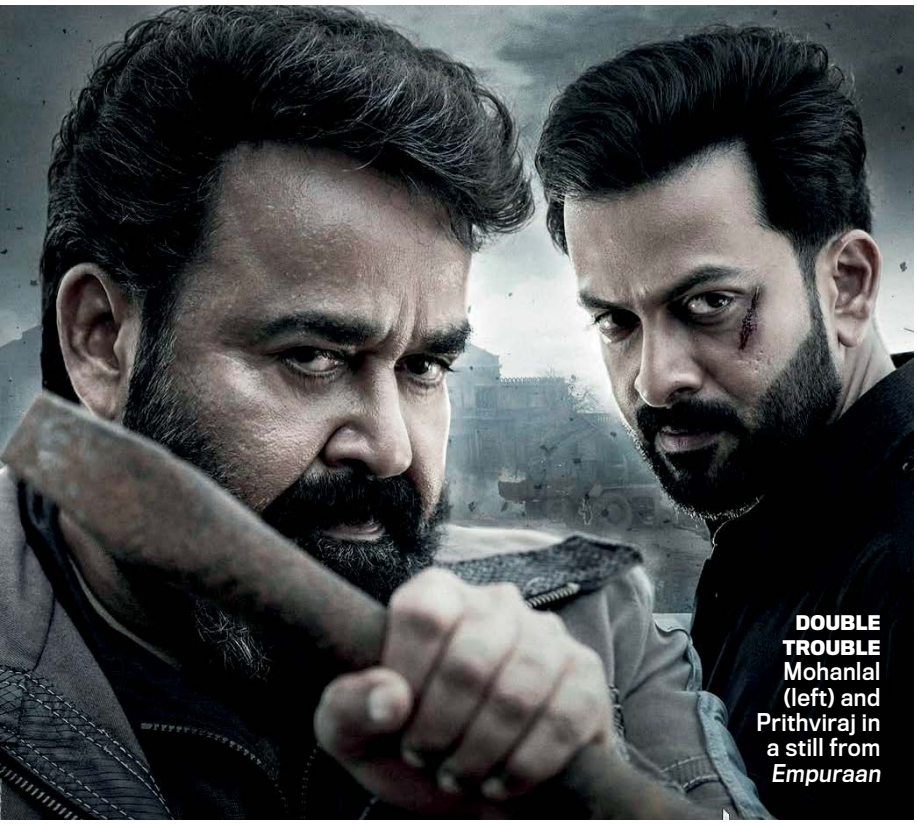


DOUBLE TROUBLE Mohanlal (left) and Prithviraj in a still from *Empuraan*

EMPURAAN CONTROVERSY

KERALA'S REEL LIFE HAZARDS

the film, we have decided together to compulsorily remove such parts from the movie". Director Prithviraj shared the post without comment while scriptwriter Murali Gopy preferred to mute his responses.

But, by then, all sides were firing away. The Congress berated the BJP for arm-twisting the filmmakers and trying to "suppress a world-class Malayalam movie" while they had given "tax-free status to a C-grade propaganda film like *The Kerala Story*". The Left, in turn, turned champion of "artists' rights", with even Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and his wife Kamala rushing to watch the film on March 30 before it was pulled and the 're-censored' version was put out.

Veteran journalist Jose Kavi told INDIA TODAY that he had watched *Empuraan* on the day it released and "would watch it again to see which scenes were deleted. It has never happened in Kerala...producers bowing down to fundamentalists".

Former CPI(M) member of Parliament and social commentator Sebastian Paul, though, views the entire drama as a "marketing strategy". "Did anyone demand the re-censorship? The producers voluntarily deleted some portions, and the lead actor, who is also a co-producer, offered an unconditional apology for stating facts 'as it hurt his loved ones' who are pro-RSS. If he was so full of regret, he should have withdrawn the film and offered an apology to save his name," says Paul. According to him, both Mohanlal and co-producer Gokulam Gopalan wanted to keep the "RSS and BJP bosses in good humour for business gains". He alleges the film worked so well that it also got the support of the Left government while director Prithviraj has been left holding the bag.

THE SANGH'S OUTRAGE OVER THE 'ANTI-NATIONAL CONTENT' HAS BEEN MATCHED BY THE OPPOSITION'S DEFENCE OF THE FILM

But even after 24 cuts and an apology, *Empuraan*, a sequel to the 2019 monster hit *Lucifer*, continues to court controversy. A section of Tamil Nadu farmers are the latest to take umbrage, apparently over an alleged defamatory portrayal of the Mullaperiyar dam issue.

In all this, what has become evident is that the film fraternity is not a worthy ally on any side. Mohanlal was earlier thought to sway on the pro-saffron side while keeping good relations with the Left and Congress leaders in the state. Prithvi's mother and veteran actress Mallika Sukumaran had been vocal for Prime Minister Narendra Modi in the last Lok Sabha election and publicly supported Rajeev Chandrasekhar for the Thiruvananthapuram Lok Sabha seat. She's now in a tit-for-tat daily scrimmage with the state BJP leaders for targeting her son and his family. Murali Gopy had scripted 'anti-Left' films earlier and was considered "soft on Hindutva". A BJP source bitterly says they now "realise there are few permanent allies" for the party in Kerala.

Meanwhile, the anti-*Empuraan* campaign has helped the ruling Left Front government in Kerala by diverting attention from the striking ASHA workers issue, which had been hogging the headlines. The film's producers won't be complaining too much either: *Empuraan* has collected Rs 250 crore worldwide till April 3 and, despite what one newspaper critic called an 'identity crisis...and a confused mess of a script', is still screening in some 750 halls to packed audiences. ■